



Evidence in Informational Text

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Reading

RI.7.1

Cite several pieces of textual evidence to support analysis of explicit statements and inferences drawn from an informational text about coral reef decline. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 7 · North Carolina · Reading; RI.7.1 — Cite several pieces of textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly as well as inferences drawn from the text.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

In informational text, explicit evidence is stated directly (a fact, a statistic, a direct claim). An inference is a reasonable conclusion built from evidence plus background knowledge. Strong analysis of informational text, like literary text, usually needs more than one piece of evidence.

Model 1 — The article states directly: "Reef temperatures rose 1.5 degrees in a decade." Is that explicit or an inference?

Explicit — it is a specific, stated fact with a number.

Model 2 — The article notes that fish populations near the reef dropped by half in the same period. What might you infer, combining both facts?

You could infer that warming water conditions are connected to the decline in fish populations, since both changes happened in the same area and timeframe.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What explicit statistic does paragraph 1 give about coral reefs' share of the ocean floor?

2. What explicit percentage does paragraph 2 give for coral cover in year one versus year nine?



The Quiet Bleaching

1. Coral reefs cover less than one percent of the ocean floor, yet they support roughly a quarter of all known marine species. Off the coast of a small research station, marine biologist Dr. Amara Osei has tracked one reef system for eleven years.
2. In her first year, the reef's coral cover measured at 68 percent, glowing with the greens and purples typical of a healthy system. By her ninth year, cover had dropped to 31 percent. Much of the remaining coral had turned a pale, bone white.
3. This whitening, called bleaching, happens when coral, stressed by unusually warm water, expels the colorful algae living in its tissue. The algae provide the coral with most of its food through photosynthesis. Without them, coral can survive for a period, but not indefinitely.
4. Dr. Osei's temperature logs show the surrounding water has warmed by 1.5 degrees Celsius over the eleven-year study, a change that sounds small but crosses a threshold that many coral species cannot tolerate for extended periods.
5. Fish surveys from the same reef tell a related story. In year one, divers counted an average of 340 fish per survey transect. By year nine, that number had fallen to roughly 170 — half of the original count.
6. Not every section of the reef has declined equally. A shaded, deeper section on the reef's northern edge, where water stays several degrees cooler, has retained nearly 60 percent coral cover throughout the study.
7. Dr. Osei now spends part of each season mapping these cooler refuges. "If warming continues," she wrote in her most recent field report, "these pockets may be what the rest of the reef eventually has to rebuild from — if it rebuilds at all."



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	It Means Explain the evidence in your own words.	And So State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What can you infer about the health of the reef system from that drop in coral cover? Cite the evidence.

2. What does paragraph 3 state explicitly about why coral bleaches?

3. What can you infer about why bleached coral is at risk, using evidence from paragraph 3?

4. What explicit temperature change does paragraph 4 report?

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. What explicit numbers does paragraph 5 give for the fish survey counts?

2. What can you infer about the relationship between coral decline and fish decline? Cite evidence from at least two paragraphs.

3. What explicit detail does paragraph 6 give about the northern section of the reef?



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. What can you infer about why the northern section has fared better? Cite evidence.

2. What does Dr. Osei state explicitly in her field report, quoted in paragraph 7?

3. What can you infer about Dr. Osei's level of concern from her quoted statement? Cite evidence.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. Cite two pieces of explicit evidence that show the reef has changed over the eleven-year study.

5. Cite evidence that supports the inference that not all parts of the reef are affected equally.

6. Why might Dr. Osei choose to study the cooler northern section more closely, based on the text?



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. Is it explicit or an inference that warmer water is the main cause of the coral decline?
Explain using the text.

2. Combine two pieces of evidence to support the inference that the reef's decline is an ongoing trend, not a one-time event.

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. What inference can you draw about the future of the reef if water temperatures continue to rise? Cite evidence.

2. Explain why a scientist like Dr. Osei tracks a reef for eleven years rather than studying it once.

Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Write one full inference about the reef's future, with two pieces of cited evidence supporting it.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. Coral reefs cover less than one percent of the ocean floor.
2. 68 percent in year one, dropping to 31 percent by year nine.
3. The reef's health has significantly declined; a drop from 68 percent to 31 percent coral cover over eight years suggests a serious, ongoing loss rather than a temporary change.
4. Coral expels the colorful algae living in its tissue when stressed by unusually warm water.
5. Bleached coral is at risk of starving, since paragraph 3 states the algae "provide the coral with most of its food" and that without them coral "can survive for a period, but not indefinitely."

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. The water has warmed by 1.5 degrees Celsius over the eleven-year study.
7. 340 fish per transect in year one, dropping to roughly 170 by year nine.
8. The two declines appear connected; paragraph 2 shows coral cover fell from 68 to 31 percent, and paragraph 5 shows fish counts fell by half over a similar period, suggesting the fish rely on the reef habitat.
9. It has retained nearly 60 percent coral cover throughout the study, in a shaded, deeper section where water stays several degrees cooler.
10. Cooler water appears to protect coral from bleaching; paragraph 6 states this section stays "several degrees cooler" and has retained far more coral cover than the reef overall.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. "If warming continues, these pockets may be what the rest of the reef eventually has to rebuild from — if it rebuilds at all."

12. She seems seriously concerned about the reef's long-term survival; the phrase "if it rebuilds at all" suggests she is uncertain whether recovery is possible.

13. The coral cover dropped from 68 to 31 percent (paragraph 2), and the water temperature rose by 1.5 degrees Celsius (paragraph 4).

14. Paragraph 6 states the northern section has retained nearly 60 percent coral cover, much higher than the reef's overall 31 percent average.

15. Because it may hold clues for how the reef could recover, since paragraph 7 suggests these cooler pockets might be what the rest of the reef "has to rebuild from."

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. It is a supported inference rather than a single explicit statement; paragraphs 3 and 4 explain the bleaching process and rising temperature, and paragraph 6's cooler-water comparison supports the connection, though no single sentence states "warm water is the main cause."
17. Coral cover fell steadily from 68 percent (year one) to 31 percent (year nine), and fish counts fell in a similar pattern across the same nine years, showing a consistent decline over time rather than a single event.
18. The reef may continue declining and could struggle to recover; Dr. Osei's own statement in paragraph 7 raises doubt about whether the reef "rebuilds at all" if warming continues.
19. Tracking it over many years allows her to see patterns and trends (like the steady drop in coral cover and fish counts) that a single visit could not reveal, and to identify areas like the cooler northern section that resist decline.
20. Answers vary; require a stated inference plus two specific, correctly cited details from the passage that reasonably support it.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source • accessed September 18, 2026

RI.7.1 — Cite several pieces of textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly as well as inferences drawn from the text.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 7: <https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/publications/catalog/>

Original passage(s), questions, and answer explanations. No official released-test items or branded curriculum reproduced.

Print US Letter at actual size. Keep the answer key separate from student pages. Single-teacher classroom or LMS use; no resale or redistribution of complete files.